



Better Questions, Better Answers

The question is the skill.

Made for the Ones Who Move Different.

— EJOSHI —

v1.4 · ejoshi.ai

SECTION 01

WHY THE QUESTION IS THE SKILL

AI doesn't make you smarter. Better questions do.

Most people who say "AI didn't help" asked a vague question and got a vague answer. The mistake isn't using the tool. It's expecting the tool to read your mind.

The good news: writing better questions is a learnable habit. Ten minutes of practice today, and the questions you ask next week will already be sharper. Over a school year, a job, a project, those small upgrades compound — into clearer thinking, faster work, and better answers from any tool, AI or otherwise.

This kit walks you through that habit. Five small moves you can practice. Four worked rewrites that show what changes when you upgrade a question. A short checklist. A practice section. The whole kit fits in about ten minutes; you'll get more out of it if you actually rewrite the practice questions instead of just reading them.

Where this skill helps beyond AI

The questions that get good answers from AI are the same questions that get good answers from a teacher, a manager, a doctor, or a friend. "Help me with this" is hard for any of them to act on. "Here's my situation, here's what I tried, here's what's confusing me — what am I missing?" is a question anyone can answer well.

This is one of the reasons "better questions" sits near the top of the Ejoshi kits. The skill travels. You'll notice it changes how you write emails. How you ask for feedback. How you bring problems to people who can help. Over time, the people around you get better at helping you — because you got better at asking.

What makes a question weak

Three things usually do it. The question is too short. The question is too broad. The question assumes the reader already knows what's in your head. The fix for all three is the same: add one more sentence. Just one. Even one extra sentence of context turns "what should I do?" into a question someone can actually answer.

This kit will give you five reusable shapes for that extra sentence — and four worked rewrites that show what happens when you use them.

Why this is different from "prompt engineering"

You'll see "prompt engineering" mentioned a lot online. Most of what's sold under that banner is overcomplicated. The real skill is much simpler: clear questions get clear answers. That's the whole game. This kit is the calm version of what other people make sound complicated. No magic words. No secret formulas. Just clarity practiced on purpose.

The Ejoshi promise. Always honest. Built for everyone, not just the people who already know. Free to access. No paywall. No gatekeeping. The future shouldn't be locked behind a paywall.

SECTION 02

WEAK VS STRONG — FOUR WORKED PAIRS

Each pair shows the weak version, the strong version, and one short note on why the upgrade works. Read them out loud if you can. Hearing the difference is half the lesson.

Pair 1 — Learning something new

Weak: *"What is photosynthesis?"*

Strong: *"Explain photosynthesis like I'm someone new to it. Use one everyday example. End with a single sentence I could repeat back."*

Why it works: the weak version asks for an answer. The strong version asks for an *experience* — a beginner-level explanation with an example and a takeaway you can use. Same topic, different output.

Pair 2 — Getting writing help

Weak: *"Help me with my essay."*

Strong: *"Here's my essay opening: [paste]. Tell me which sentence is weakest, what's missing, and one stronger opening I could try. Be direct."*

Why it works: the weak version is a wish. The strong version is a request — specific feedback, specific shape, specific tone. The AI can act on the strong version. It can only guess at the weak one.

Pair 3 — Making a decision

Weak: *"Is this a good idea?"*

Strong: *"Here's my idea: [describe]. What are three reasons it could work, two reasons it might not, and one question I should answer before committing?"*

Why it works: "good or bad?" is a closed question that flattens the thinking. The strong version asks for *shape* — pros, cons, and the next question — which is what you actually need to decide well.

Pair 4 — Asking for an opinion

Weak: *"What do you think?"*

Strong: *"Read this and tell me three things: (1) what's most convincing, (2) what's weakest, (3) what would push it from a 7/10 to a 9/10."*

Why it works: the weak version asks for a feeling. The strong version asks for a structured critique with a clear improvement target. You can edit on the strong answer; you can't on the weak one.

A bonus pair — getting unstuck

Weak: *"I'm stuck."*

Strong: *"I'm stuck on [task]. I've tried [list of what you've tried]. Here's what I think the blocker might be: [your guess]. What am I not seeing?"*

Why it works: "I'm stuck" is one of the hardest questions to help with because the helper has to guess the entire shape of the problem. The strong version shows the work, names the suspected blocker, and asks the AI to find the gap — which is exactly what AI is good at.

The move. Every "after" version is longer than the "before." That's not bloat — it's specificity. Specific in, specific out.

SECTION 03

FIVE QUESTION PATTERNS BY PURPOSE

Five reusable shapes. Memorize the spine; swap the topic.

The Learning Pattern

"Explain [topic] like I'm new to it. Use one everyday analogy. End with a question that checks if I got it."

When to use it: any time you're trying to understand something for the first time. The analogy bridges the new to the known; the question catches gaps.

The Decision Pattern

"I'm deciding between [A] and [B]. Here's my situation: [context]. What are the trade-offs, and which one fits if I care most about [priority]?"

When to use it: anytime you're choosing between two real options. The "priority" line forces the AI to actually weight the trade-offs instead of giving you a generic both-sides answer.

The Writing Pattern

"Rewrite this in three versions: more confident, more friendly, and shorter. Keep each under [X words]: [paste your text]."

When to use it: any time the words you have are almost-right. Three versions give you a sense of range; you'll usually find your final answer somewhere between two of them.

The Debug Pattern

"Here's the problem: [describe]. Here's what I tried: [list]. Here's what I expected: [describe]. What's the most likely cause, and what should I check first?"

When to use it: anytime something isn't working — homework, code, a recipe, a relationship message. Structured context makes the AI's diagnosis usable instead of speculative.

The Exploration Pattern

"I'm curious about [broad topic]. Give me a one-paragraph overview, then five questions I should explore next, ranked by how foundational they are."

When to use it: anytime you're starting from scratch on a subject. The five questions become your reading list. The one-paragraph overview keeps you from going down rabbit holes too early.

Mixing patterns

These aren't rigid templates. The patterns combine. A real prompt might use the Decision pattern's "trade-offs and priority" framing with the Learning pattern's "explain like I'm new to it" tone. Once you internalize the spines, the patterns blur — you're just picking the right shape for what you actually need.

Why these five and not twenty

Most "AI prompt guide" lists have thirty patterns. That's the problem. Thirty templates are impossible to memorize. Five fit in your head. And five cover most of the situations that matter: learning something, deciding between two things, writing something, fixing something, exploring something new. If you find yourself reaching for a sixth pattern often, build your own. Save it. That's how you grow your toolkit on purpose.

One small habit. Pick the pattern that matches your purpose before you start typing.
The whole question goes faster from there.

SECTION 04

THE QUESTION UPGRADE CHECKLIST

A five-item gut check. If your question is missing two or more of these, it's probably weak. Annotated so you remember why each item matters.

- **[] Did I say WHO this is for?** (me, a child, a beginner, an expert) — AI defaults to averages; tell it the audience and the answer sharpens.
- **[] Did I say WHAT FORMAT I want?** (a list, a paragraph, an example, a comparison table) — Format constraints reshape the answer more than people expect.
- **[] Did I give CONTEXT?** (the situation, what I already know, what I've tried) — Context is the single highest-leverage upgrade. Most weak questions become strong ones with one more sentence of context.
- **[] Did I set a LENGTH?** (under 100 words, two paragraphs, one sentence) — Length forces choice. Without it, AI defaults to verbose averages.
- **[] Is my question SPECIFIC enough that a wrong answer would be obvious?** — This is the meta-test. If "any reasonable-sounding answer" would satisfy you, the question is too vague.

When you've got all five

A question with all five elements feels long. That's the trade. Your typing time goes up by maybe a minute. Your back-and-forth time drops by ten. On the questions that actually matter, that math is always in your favor. On trivial questions, skip the checklist — overkill is also a mistake.

You don't need all five. Aim for three. The strongest prompts usually have audience + context + format. Length is optional. The "wrong answer would be obvious" test is the safety net.

SECTION 05

PRACTICE — UPGRADE THESE THREE

For each, rewrite using the checklist. Worked answers below. Cover them and try yours first.

1. *"Tell me about the American Revolution."*

Your upgrade: _____

A worked version: *"Explain the American Revolution to me like I'm in early high school history class. Hit three things: why it started, what changed because of it, and one surprising fact. Keep it to four paragraphs."*

What changed: audience set (early high school), structure requested (three points), length capped (four paragraphs).

2. *"How do I write a good conclusion?"*

Your upgrade: _____

A worked version: *"Here's the final paragraph of my essay: [paste]. Tell me what's weak, what's missing, and rewrite one stronger version in my voice — direct and not flowery."*

What changed: actual text shared, specific feedback asked, voice constraint added.

3. *"What should I do for my science project?"*

Your upgrade: _____

A worked version: *"I'm in [class context]. We have to do a science project on any topic. I'm curious about how memory works. Give me five project ideas at the intersection of memory and something I can actually test in a week with household materials. List them in order of effort, lowest first."*

What changed: context loaded (class + topic interest), constraint added (testable in a week, household materials), structure requested (ranked by effort).

What to notice. The "after" versions feel like more work to write. They are — by about thirty seconds. They save you ten rounds of follow-up. The math is in your favor.

Bonus practice: the "rewrite my old question" exercise

Open any AI tool you've used recently. Scroll back to a question that gave you a weak answer. Rewrite it with the checklist. Send the upgraded version. Watch what changes.

This is the single fastest way to feel the difference. You already have a baseline — the original answer that disappointed you. The upgraded version usually lands closer to what you actually needed. That feeling, the contrast between "vague answer" and "useful answer," is what cements the habit faster than reading about it ever will.

Why the rewrite practice matters more than the new-question practice

When you write a new question, you don't know what a good answer looks like — so you can't tell if your upgrade landed. When you rewrite an old question, you've already seen what a bad answer looks like. The contrast is what teaches. The whole skill is built on noticing the difference.

SECTION 06

ONE HABIT TO TAKE WITH YOU

The 30-second question habit.

Before you send any question — to AI, to a teacher, to a teammate — pause for half a minute. Ask yourself: *"Is this specific enough that the wrong answer would be obvious?"*

If yes, send it. If no, add one sentence of context and try again.

Half a minute. Once a day. For a month. That's the whole habit. You'll be the person who gets useful answers because you ask better questions. Not because you're smarter. Because you slowed down for thirty seconds.

A note on patience

The first few times you upgrade a question, it feels slower. By the tenth time, it's faster overall, because the answer comes back closer to what you needed. By the hundredth time, you don't notice you're doing it — it's just how you ask. That's the whole arc.

The mistake to avoid

Don't try to upgrade every question. That kills the habit before it starts. Pick the questions that matter — the ones where a wrong answer would actually cost you time, money, or a do-over. For trivial stuff, ask whatever comes out of your head; the AI will be fine. Save the upgrade move for the questions that count. That's how a thirty-second pause stays sustainable instead of becoming a chore.

SECTION 07

THE QUESTION IS THE SKILL

This kit isn't about AI. AI was the excuse to talk about questions.

The questions that get good answers from a chatbot are the same questions that get good answers from a manager, a doctor, a parent, or a friend. "Help me" is hard for anyone to act on. "Here's my situation, here's what I tried, here's what's confusing me — what am I missing?" is something anyone can respond to.

Get good at the question, and you get good at every conversation that depends on one.

The bigger pattern

If this kit lands, you might notice something quieter underneath it: the questions you ask shape the answers you get — but the answers you get also shape the questions you'll ask next. It's a small loop. Better question, better answer, more confidence to ask the next question better. Confidence isn't the starting fuel for learning. It's a byproduct of asking well a few times in a row.

That's the whole compounding game. Not just with AI. With everything that depends on you knowing what you actually want to know.

Start with one upgrade today. Save the questions that worked. Come back when you need it.

— Ejoshi ejoshi.ai